



KAVERI LALCHAND, who runs the Chennai-based publishing house Blaft with Rakesh Khanna (right), has published pop art by Vishwajyoti Ghosh and says there is a market for such projects in the future.



artists from Kolkata, supported by author Rimi B. Chatterjee, has started an English magazine, *Project C*, which has a Facebook page and a Google group. Similarly, a couple of Hyderabad-based writers, Jaideep Unudurti and Jasraman Singh, along with Kolkata-based artist Harsho Mohan Chatteraj, have come up with a 120-page book, *The Hyderabad Graphic Novel Project*. It retells the

YOGALICIOUS, A WORK PUBLISHED BY LALCHAND AND KHANNA

Started in 2007 with much fanfare with Anindya Roy after Banerjee's two graphic novels, *Corridor* (2004, Penguin) and *The Barn Owl's Wondrous Capers* (2007, Penguin) were well received by readers, Phantomville promised to publish only graphic novels. But after two further publications, *The Believers* and *Kashmir Pending*, both based on Kashmir militancy, the publishing house reportedly suffered internally and has not published a single publication since.

This is why Coimbatore-based Bharath Murthy came up with the idea of the print-on-demand self-publishing format. He heads the Comixindia movement, which began in October 2009, and the first comics magazine is likely to be due in a month. It operates through an online publishing company called Pothi.com, where buyers request the magazine and he delivers it. "We have devised a profit-sharing

system, and we have the open submissions format with the contributors," he explains. Murthy has already advertised for the first three issues of it, the first one, *Random Selections*, a general issue, the second, by women artists on women's issues titled *Girl Power*, and yet another based on reportage. "Each issue is 250 pages with 10-15 contributors, touching upon subjects such as growing up in Bihar in the 1980s or life in small-town Assam," says Murthy, who holds a degree in painting from The Maharaja Sayajirao University, Baroda, and another one in filmmaking from the Satyajit Ray Film and Television Institute, Kolkata.

Similarly, some students and alumni at Kolkata's Jadavpur University have also started a comics-based magazine under the name of *Drighanchu*. The first issue is out and tries to make readers aware of new forms of media. Another group of

story of the Andhra capital through old timers and is due to hit the stands soon. Others, such as Kolkata's Sarbajit Sen and Delhi's Vishwajyoti Ghosh, are talking about climate change through their artwork. Sen has released a book on carbon dioxide emissions, while Ghosh has a column called *Acid Test* in the environment magazine *Down to Earth*.

George Mathen, also the famous drummer of the rock band Lounge Piranha, has used allegory to get the message across. Mathen, based in Bangalore, has almost eliminated the use of words in his novel, *Moonward*, which deals with existential angst on a fictional planet. "Mathen is environmentally conscious," says Kaveri Lalchand, who runs Blaft with Rakesh Khanna, says that there is a market for such unusual projects in the future.

Once a theory, that comics are as effective in taking the message across as written text, is now a belief. ■